

Shannon L. Coleman, PhD

Experience Research and Strategy Leader • AI Product Measurement • Regulated & Enterprise Markets

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[Ground Truth \(Substack\)](#) | Writing on AI product measurement, capability evaluation, and research practice

[The Capability Question](#) | An AI-powered research design tool for measuring what AI enablement does to human judgment

SUMMARY

Experience research and strategy leader with 15+ years across DoD modernization, enterprise AI, regulated HealthTech, and FinTech. Comes into complex, ambiguous situations, figures out what is actually true, and moves organizations toward better decisions. Equally fluent in a regression model and a 90-minute interview. Secret Clearance (Inactive).

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS

- **\$15B DoD Acquisition:** Drove the \$15B Advana multi-vendor recompile, the largest defense analytics platform contract in recent history, through a multi-method research program across 1,382 enterprise users
- **XLA Standards in \$5.7B Contracts:** Set the first contract-level UX performance standard for 800,000+ personnel by defining and operationalizing Experience Level Agreement standards embedded into \$5.7B Air Force EITaaS vendor contracts
- **Commander's Commendation:** Awarded U.S. Air Force Commander's Challenge Coin for shifting IT modernization to a user-centric service model, setting foundational standards for DAF digital transformation
- **950+ Participant Panel Built from Zero:** Reduced external recruitment spend to \$0 and cut study recruitment timelines by at least 2 weeks per study by building and scaling a 950+ participant proprietary research panel under HIPAA-adjacent and FDIC-regulated constraints
- **Trust-Transfer Model:** Contributed to an AI health platform's first six-figure service agreement and growth from users in the hundreds to 16,000+ by developing a B2B2C go-to-market framework reorienting channel strategy toward self-funded employers, unions, and advocacy organizations

EXPERIENCE

Principal Research & Strategy Advisor | Coleman Advisory

2022–Present

Independent consulting practice focused on mixed methods UX research and product strategy for early-stage HealthTech and FinTech platforms in regulated markets, working directly with founders and executive teams.

- Grew an AI-powered health platform from users in the hundreds to 16,000+ and contributed to their first six-figure service agreement by surfacing the "Not for Me" Paradox and a trust gap at onboarding; the resulting Trust-Transfer Model reoriented channel strategy toward self-funded employers, unions, and advocacy organizations
- Accelerated compliance approval cycles by 3 weeks and eliminated late-stage engineering rework by reframing UX and compliance as a single workstream across a Web3 FinTech engagement, aligning onboarding and transaction flows with regulatory risk from the start
- Prevented approximately 2 sprints of misaligned engineering work and improved task completion confidence by 35% by catching a churn-driving score-first UX pattern in a 6-user prototype test before development began

Research & Strategy Lead, DoD | Isobar Public Sector

2022–2024

Principal researcher and strategist for two large-scale DoD programs serving a combined 900,000+ users and personnel.

Advana | DoD CDAO Enterprise Analytics Platform

- Established the evidentiary foundation for all subsequent platform and roadmap recommendations through a multi-method research program across 1,382 enterprise users, spanning survey, interview, card sort, tree test, and two rounds of usability testing
- Directly informed a DoD-level development pause for infrastructure improvements by surfacing six simultaneous failure modes and reframing discrete issues as a structural challenge on a platform that had scaled faster than its architecture, its UX, and its organizational support model
- Diagnosed a content-findability crisis affecting 36% of users as an information architecture failure rather than a user education problem, delivering the sitemap, navigation redesign, and content model to resolve it
- Contributed to the \$15B multi-vendor recompile and two product roadmaps by delivering findings and strategic recommendations directly to the Chief Experience Architect and Chief Product Officer

Air Force EITaaS | Enterprise IT Modernization (\$5.7B program)

- Drove 84% faster system startup, 59% faster data transfer, and 92% reduction in security event workload by developing a persona and workflow research framework across nine deployment sites, establishing the segmentation foundation that enabled XLA standard definition
- Institutionalized UX performance expectations for 800,000+ personnel by defining and operationalizing Experience Level Agreement (XLA) standards embedded into \$5.7B vendor contracts

- Validated the program model before the Air Force committed to scaling by measuring IT satisfaction rising to 74/100 against a baseline of 44 at comparable pre-transition bases, with speed satisfaction at 73 versus mid-40s elsewhere
- Awarded U.S. Air Force Commander's Challenge Coin for shifting IT modernization to a user-centric service model, setting foundational standards for DAF digital transformation

Research & Strategy Analyst | Crowley Webb / Praxis

2020–2022

- Reduced external recruitment spend to \$0 and cut study recruitment timelines by at least 2 weeks per study by building and scaling a 950+ participant research panel from zero under HIPAA-adjacent and FDIC-regulated constraints
- Increased trial recruitment signups for F500 pharmaceutical clients including Pfizer, Eli Lilly, Merck, J&J, and AbbVie by conducting qualitative interviews, large-scale surveys, social listening, and patient experience research that directly informed site selection adjustments and messaging changes
- Improved recruitment conversion across concurrent multi-million-dollar Phase II/III campaigns by applying quantitative analysis to real-time performance insights, driving site selection adjustments, messaging changes, and budget reallocation
- Reduced overall project timelines by 2–4 days per study and eliminated redundant overhead by managing research operations for a 7–10 person team and standardizing recruitment workflows across concurrent client programs

Doctoral Researcher | University at Buffalo, Psychology & Quantitative Methods

2014–2019

- Led multi-year mixed methods longitudinal research integrating qualitative and advanced quantitative modeling to identify dropout risk patterns in digital learning environments; applied survival analysis and logistic regression to high-dimensional behavioral datasets
- Managed a 25+ person research operations team, improving interrater reliability by 60%+, reducing costly re-coding cycles, producing consistently defensible findings, and strengthening the evidentiary basis for policy recommendations presented at the White House

Early Career

- Fisher-Price:** Informed a 4-product category launch and evaluated 100+ concepts and prototypes across multiple product lines by leading usability and developmental research in partnership with Product, Engineering, and Design
- Segmedica, Inc.:** Designed and analyzed a 35,000+ response national survey across 30+ pharmaceutical brands, packaged into a proprietary strategic research product

EDUCATION

PhD & MA, Psychology & Quantitative Methods — University at Buffalo, State University of New York

BS, Education — Fredonia, State University of New York

CORE EXPERTISE

Research Methods

Mixed methods research, usability testing and prototype validation, in-depth interviews and contextual inquiry, survey design and quantitative analysis, longitudinal and behavioral data modeling, survival analysis, logistic regression, A/B testing

Strategy & Product

Product roadmapping, strategic framework development, go-to-market research, XLA and CX measurement, persona and segmentation frameworks, information architecture, Agile research integration

Research Operations

Research program design, panel development and management, research ops standardization, cross-functional research leadership, compliance-driven research (HIPAA, GDPR, ISO 27001:2022)

Domains

AI products, HealthTech, GovTech / DoD, enterprise platforms, regulated and compliance-driven systems, classified environments, Web3 / FinTech

Research & Design Tools

Qualtrics, dscout, Figma, Miro, UserTesting, Optimal Workshop, Dovetail, Zoom, UserZoom, User Interviews

AI Tools

Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Dovetail AI, Notion AI, Otter.ai, Miro Assist

Statistical & Analytics Tools

R, Python, SPSS, Excel, Tableau, Power BI, Azure SQL, Amplitude, GA4, Google Search Console

Platforms

Jira, Confluence, ServiceNow, GitHub, Slack